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A HISTORICAL STUDY OF THE PRESERVATION OF THE HOLY QURAN

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Introduction

The Holy Quran is the literal, verbatim word of Almighty Allah revealed to Prophet Muhammad (SAW) through the Angel Jibreel (AS) over a period of approximately 23 years (610 CE – 632 CE). Unlike previous divine scriptures that were altered, corrupted, or lost over time, the Holy Quran remains in its pristine, original form—without a single letter, word, or vowel sign changed since its revelation. The preservation of the Quran is a monumental historical phenomenon that relies on a unique, dual system of defense: oral memorization (*Hifz*) and written documentation (*Kitabah*).

While human historical diligence played a crucial role, the primary foundation of the Quran's absolute preservation is the Divine Guarantee explicitly stated by Allah (SWT) in the Quran itself:

"Indeed, it is We who sent down the Quran and indeed, We will be its guardian."

(Surah Al-Hijr, 15:9)

This divine promise sets the Quran apart from all other religious texts in human history, ensuring that no falsehood can approach it from before it or behind it.

2. Preservation During the Era of Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ)

2.1 Dual Method: Oral Memorization and Written Recording

During the lifetime of Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ), the revelation descended in fragments—verses and surahs—in response to specific events, inquiries, and developmental stages of the Muslim community. To preserve these divine messages instantly, the Prophet (ﷺ) employed two parallel methods:

1. **Oral Preservation (Hifz):** The Prophet (SAW) was the first to memorize every revealed verse immediately upon receiving it from Angel Jibreel (AS). He would repeat it to ensure perfection and then recite it to his Companions (*Sahabah*). Arabs of the 7th century possessed extraordinary oral memory, capable of retaining lengthy genealogies and thousands of poetic lines after a single hearing. Hundreds of Sahabah memorized the entire Quran word-for-word during the Prophet's lifetime.
2. **Written Preservation (Kitabah):** Although paper was not available in 7th-century Arabia, the Prophet (SAW) appointed official scribes of revelation (*Kuttab al-Wahy*)—including Zaid ibn Thabit, Ali ibn Abi Talib, Ubayy ibn Ka'b, and Mu'awiyah ibn Abi Sufyan (RA). Whenever a revelation descended, the Prophet (SAW) instructed his scribes to write it down on available materials such as parchment (leather), flat stones, palm branches , shoulder blades of camels, and wooden boards.

2.2 The Annual Recital and Structural Arrangement

The arrangement of verses within surahs, and the order of surahs themselves, was not done chronologically or by human editorial choice. It was divinely instructed by Allah through Angel Jibreel (ؑ). Whenever a new

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verse was revealed, the Prophet (SAW) explicitly told the scribes: ***"Place these verses in the surah where such-and-such is mentioned."***

Furthermore, every year during the holy month of Ramadan, Angel Jibreel (AS) visited Prophet Muhammad (SAW) to recite and review the entire Quran revealed up to that point. In the final year of the Prophet's life, this review—known as *Al-'Ardah al-Akhirah* (The Final Recital)—was conducted twice. Zaid ibn Thabit (RA) and other chief scribes were present during this final audit, ensuring that the written records and oral memorizations perfectly matched the final approved divine text.

3. Compilation During the Caliphate of Abu Bakr Siddique (رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ)

3.1 Historical Trigger: The Battle of Yamama (12 AH)

When Prophet Muhammad (SAW) passed away in 632 CE, the complete Quran was fully written down on various scattered materials and fully memorized by hundreds of Sahabah. However, it was not yet bound into a single, unified volume (*Suhuf*), because revelation remained open until the Prophet's death.

Shortly after the Prophet's death, during the Caliphate of Abu Bakr Siddique (RA), false prophets arose, leading to the Ridda (Apostasy) Wars. The most fierce conflict was the Battle of Yamama (12 AH / 633 CE). In this battle, nearly 70 top *Huffaz* (memorisers of the Quran), including senior companions, were martyred in a single day.

3.2 Hazrat Umar Proposal and Abu Bakr Hesitation

Seeing the heavy loss of Quranic memorisers, Hazrat Umar ibn al-Khattab (RA) became deeply concerned that if more battles occurred, large portions of the Quranic memory might be lost. He approached Caliph Abu Bakr (RA) and suggested: *"I strongly advise that you order the compilation of the Quran into a single, official volume."*

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Abu Bakr (RA) initially hesitated, asking: *"How can I do something that the Messenger of Allah (SAW) did not do during his lifetime?"* Hazrat Umar (RA) argued: *"By Allah, this is good and necessary for the protection of Islam."* After deep reflection and consultation, Allah opened Abu Bakr's heart to the wisdom of Umar's proposal.

3.3 The Methodology of Zaid ibn Thabit (RA)

Abu Bakr (RA) selected Zaid ibn Thabit (RA) to lead this critical task. Zaid was chosen because he was a chief scribe of revelation, present at the Final Recital with Jibreel (AS), young, intelligent, and known for his impeccable integrity.

Zaid (RA) applied an extraordinarily strict, multi-layered verification methodology before accepting any written verse:

1. **Oral Verification:** The verse had to be verified against the memory of prominent Huffaz.
2. **Written Verification:** The verse had to exist in written form on material inscribed in the direct presence of the Prophet (SAW).
3. **Two Eye-Witnesses:** Zaid required two upright witnesses to testify that the specific written script was drafted directly in the Prophet's presence.
4. **Personal Memory:** Zaid checked the record against his own extensive memory.

Through this foolproof process, Zaid compiled the complete Quran onto uniform sheets of parchment, creating the first official master manuscript known as the *Suhuf*. This manuscript remained with Abu Bakr (RA), then passed to Umar (RA) during his caliphate, and eventually to Hazrat Hafsah bint Umar (RA), the Prophet's widow.

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4. Standardization During the Caliphate of Uthman (RA)

4.1 Historical Trigger: Dialectical Variations in the Muslim Empire

During the Caliphate of Uthman ibn Affan (RA) (644–656 CE), the Islamic state expanded rapidly across Persia, Syria, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and North Africa. Millions of non-Arab populations embraced Islam.

To facilitate recitation for diverse Arab tribes, the Prophet (SAW) had been permitted by Allah to teach the Quran in seven Arabic dialects (*Ahruf*). However, as new Muslims in distant provinces learned the Quran from different companions (e.g., Syrians following Ubayy ibn Ka'b, Iraqis following Ibn Mas'ud), disputes began to emerge regarding minor pronunciation and dialectical differences.

During the military campaign in Armenia, general Hudhayfah ibn al-Yaman (RA) witnessed soldiers arguing fiercely over whose recitation was superior. Alarmed, Hudhayfah rushed to Madinah and pleaded with Caliph Uthman: *"O Leader of the Believers! Save this Ummah before they differ regarding their Book as the Jews and Christians differed before them!"*

4.2 The Committee and Standardization Criteria

Caliph Uthman (RA) immediately formed a high-level committee of senior scribes, led once again by Zaid ibn Thabit (RA), alongside Abdullah ibn al-Zubayr, Sa'id ibn al-'As, and Abdur-Rahman ibn al-Harith (RA).

Uthman (RA) borrowed the master manuscript (*Suhuf*) from Hazrat Hafsah (RA) and issued two critical directives to the committee:

1. Write the copies strictly in the primary dialect of **Quraish** (the dialect in which the Quran was revealed to Prophet Muhammad SAW).
2. Ensure that the text preserves all valid recitations established during the Final Recital while removing all personal commentary or non-essential dialectical spelling.

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4.3 Distribution of the Mushaf al-Uthmani and Burning of Unofficial Copies

The committee meticulously produced several official standardized copies, known as the **Mushaf al-Uthmani**. Uthman (RA) retained one master copy in Madinah (*Mushaf al-Imam*) and dispatched official copies to major regional capitals of the Islamic empire: Mecca, Kufa, Basra, Damascus, and Bahrain.

Along with each copy, Uthman (RA) sent a master *Qari* (expert Quranic reciter) to teach the populace the exact oral pronunciation, proving that written manuscripts alone were never detached from authentic oral recitation.

To eliminate future confusion and safeguard unity, Uthman (RA) ordered that all other private, incomplete, or dialectically variant manuscripts across the provinces be recalled and burned. The entire community of Sahabah, including Hazrat Ali ibn Abi Talib (RA), unanimously praised and supported Uthman's decisive action.

5. Summary of the Three Major Eras of Preservation

Historic Era	Primary Leader	Main motive	Outcome
Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ)	Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) & scribes	Direct divine revelation over 23 years; need for instant recording	Verses recorded on leather/bone/palm; memorized by 100s of Sahabah
Abu Bakr Siddique (رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ.)	Abu Bakr (RA), Umar (RA) & Zaid ibn Thabit (RA)	Martyrdom of 70+ Huffaz at the Battle of Yamama (12 AH)	First single compiled master volume (*Suhuf*) verified with 2 witnesses
Uthman Ibne Affan (رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ.)	Uthman (RA) & Committee of 4 Scribes	Disputes over regional Arabic dialects in expanding empire	Standardized Quraishi text (*Mushaf al-Uthmani*) sent to all provinces

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6. Later Stage Enhancements: Dots, Diacritical Marks, and Chapters

The original Uthmanic script (*Rasm al-Uthmani*) was written in the early Arabic script without dotting (*I'jām*) or short vowel signs (*Tashkeel / Harakāt*). Native Arabs of the 7th century did not require dots or vowels because their natural linguistic fluency and oral training enabled them to read plain Arabic letters perfectly.

However, as millions of non-Arabs entered Islam during the Umayyad and Abbasid Dynasties, linguistic mispronunciations began to appear. To safeguard the reading for future generations, Muslim scholars introduced gradual, non-structural formatting improvements:

1. **Addition of Dots (Nuqat):** Abu al-Aswad al-Du'ali, Nasr ibn 'Asim, and Yahya ibn Ya'mur introduced letter dots to distinguish similar consonants (e.g., separating Bā, Tā, Thā, and Yā).
2. **Vowel Marks (Harakāt / Tashkeel):** Khalil ibn Ahmad al-Farahidi (d. 786 CE) developed the modern system of Fatha, Kasra, Damma, and Sukun, enabling non-Arabs to pronounce every letter with exact grammatical accuracy.
3. **Structural Division:** Later scholars added markers for Surah headings, Ayah numbers, Manzil/Juz divisions (30 parts) for daily recitation, and Tajweed symbols.

It is vital to emphasize that these visual enhancements changed zero words or meanings; they merely served as phonetic aids to preserve the original, authentic pronunciation established by Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ).

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7. Conclusion

In conclusion, the preservation of the Holy Quran is an unparalleled miracle in human literary and religious history. Through a flawless combination of continuous oral transmission (*Tawātur*) by millions of memorisers across centuries and rigorous, multi-checked written documentation starting from the Prophet's own scribes to Caliph Abu Bakr and Caliph Uthman (RA), the Quran has reached us today in the exact form it was revealed.

Modern historical manuscripts (such as the Birmingham Quran manuscript carbon-dated to the era of the Prophet SAW, and the Topkapi and Tashkent manuscripts) match the printed Quran published today word-for-word, letter-for-letter. This extraordinary historical trajectory stands as a living fulfillment of Allah's divine promise: *"Indeed, We will be its guardian."*

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